‘Don’t worry about this, Dave. You’ve had an unbelievable tournament. You’ve kept us in games to get us this far. You had no chance: the goal was a freak. Forget about it. Don’t let people see you like this now.’

Dave didn’t say anything. I remembered what I’d needed in the dressing room in Saint-Etienne. I remembered Tony Adams being the one who’d been there for me. Here, now, I couldn’t be inside Dave’s head in those moments but I felt like I knew what he needed from a team-mate:

‘Come on, Dave, let’s go for a walk round. Let’s go down and see the England fans.’

Those supporters were great. We knew they were as disappointed as we were but they stood in their seats, waiting for us and applauding us when we came in front of them. No bitterness, no threat towards us or anybody else; behind us to the end. They’d been like that throughout the tournament: the best fans in Japan. Maybe the Brazilians picked up on that spirit: their supporters were clapping us as well as their own team. They were celebrating Brazil advancing but they gave the English players respect, too, and I admired that a lot.

When we got back and sat down in the dressing room, it was very quiet, players thinking their own thoughts. It wasn’t only the game we’d just played. You could see ten months of top-level soccer catching up with the lads in the minutes after we lost to Brazil. It was as if the life had been drained away out of us. Sven was the only one to break the silence.

‘I’m very proud of you all. Not just what you’ve done in the past three weeks but what you had to do to get us to the World Cup in the first place. Today we’re very disappointed. We thought we could go further in this tournament. I believed we could. But this is soccer. This is how the game goes. When your time comes, it’ll happen. You’re good enough. You should know that.’

I was off in a world of my own. Every player in the dressing room was. There was nothing more to say than Sven had just said. It seemed to take forever—it was a real effort—just to get up off the bench and get to the shower and then change. We took a long time dragging ourselves out of the stadium. When we finally made it to our coach, we pulled away immediately behind the Brazilians. Ronaldhino was in the back, playing a set of samba drums; he was so happy. I’m not surprised. His goal had gotten his team to the semis. At that moment, my head ached with what-ifs. I spoke to Victoria on the cell phone: